



Peter "Gumpa" Lee

**The Family of Peter ("Gumpa") and Josephine Lee
of the
Slave Ship *Clotilda* and Africatown, Alabama**

by

Llewellyn "Lew" Toulmin, PhD, FRGS

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INTRODUCTION

This short paper presents information on the family and some first and second generation descendants of Peter “Gumpa” Lee and his wife Josephine Lee, both of whom were on the last slave ship to enter US waters, the *Clotilda*, and were also co-founders of Africatown, Alabama.

This research was requested in 2023 by a UCLA archaeologist, Madison “Maddy” Aubey, who is researching the artifacts excavated in 2010 from the home of Peter and Josephine by a team from William and Mary College in Virginia. This was the only archaeological effort to date undertaken in Africatown.

The research question asked by Ms. Aubey was, “Who were the children of Peter and Josephine Lee who resided in their household?” This question resulted from a finding of children’s toys in the archaeological material found at the Lee site. Genealogical evidence relevant to this question is presented below. Unlike my other *Clotilda/Africatown* reports (available on Academia.edu or on my website www.themosttraveled.com), this paper does not attempt to trace a line from the propoiti (Peter and Josephine Lee, the target ancestors) to the present, but only to answer the limited research question posed.

Some biographical information on Peter Lee (with very little on Josephine, unfortunately), and on Africatown and the *Clotilda*, can be found in the following sources:

- Sylviane A. Diouf, *Dreams of Africa in Alabama* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007)
- Zora Neale Hurston, *Barracoon* (New York: HarperCollins, 2018)
- Ben Raines, *The Last Slave Ship* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 2022)
- Natalie S. Robertson, *The Slave Ship Clotilda and the Making of Africatown USA* (Praeger: Westport, CT, 2008)
- Emma Roche, *Historic Sketches of the South* (Knickerbocker Press, 1914), partially reprinted as *The Last Voyage of the Clotilda* (Coppell, Texas: 2022)
- Henry Romeyn, *Little Africa* (Hampton, Virginia: Hampton Institute, 1897)
- Mary McNeil Scott, “Affika Town,” *Wilcox Progressive Era*, 4 June 1894, www.newspapers.com/image/308670655/?terms=affika&match=1
- Nick Tabor, *Africatown: America’s Last Slave Ship and the Community it Created* (Washington, DC: Mahogany Books: 2023).

This paper does not attempt to provide a full or partial biography of Peter and Josephine Lee, but some biographical information can be gleaned from the genealogical data presented below.

Annexes provide information on Nick Caffey, who adopted Peter Lee’s grandchildren, and on the author of this paper.

Abbreviations used below in this paper include the following:

aft: after
b. born
b.c. born circa
bef. before
d. died
d. bef. died before
s/b should be

Key persons in the evidence below are underlined.

GENEALOGICAL EVIDENCE

This section presents various evidence items, sometimes with a discussion of the value or relevance of the particular item.

The 1870 (July 15th) US Census for Mobile, Alabama, Beat 3 shows “Peter Leek” (which should be Peter Lee) as a black male laborer, 40 years old (hence b.c. 1830), b. in Africa, both parents of foreign birth, cannot read or write, male citizen of the US over age 21. His wife is “Josephina Leek” (should be Josephine Lee), black female housewife, 30 years old (hence b.c. 1840), b. in Africa, both parents of foreign birth, cannot read or write. Their children are Lucy, 6, Charles, 3, Seely or Celia (transcribed in Ancestry from the Census) as “Luly” but this appears to be wrong or a nickname), 2, and Anderson, 6/12 (but see below for issues with this name), all black, all with the last name of Lee, and all b. in Alabama.

That this 1870 record is for Peter Lee (and his family), not a different person named Peter Leek, is proven by the following:

1. His spouse is Josephina (s/b Josephine)
2. The children as listed appear in the 1880 Census below, when corrections are taken into account
3. Peter “Leek” and Josephine “Leek” were b. in Africa, a very rare birth location
4. The neighbors of Peter “Leek,” on the same Census page, include the known *Clotilda*/Africatown residents, b. in Africa, of: Polee and Rose Allen (in Diouf, p. 6 and Hurston, p. 145), John and Ernest Auro (Diouf, p. 6), Cudgenlie and Phily Adams (Phily is in Diouf, p. 6), and Clara Turner (Diouf, p. 6, Hurston, p. 146)
5. Peter “Gumpa” Lee was known to be a leader of Africatown and to be living on a plot of land near the other leaders, including Polee Allen, listed immediately above.

Since the first child, Lucy, was b.c. 1864, it is reasonable to assume that Peter and Josephine formed a liaison or marriage in about 1862-3.

The 1880 (June 25th) US Census for Mobile, Alabama, Whistler, shows Peter Lee as a black married male laborer, 40 years old (hence b.c. 1840), b. in Africa, both parents b. in Africa,

cannot read or write. His wife Josephine Lee, black married female keeping house, 32 years old (hence b.c. 1848), b. in Africa, both parents b. in Africa, cannot read or write. Their children are Charles, 15; Celia, student (this appears to be the Seely/Celia/Luly that appeared as 2 years old in the 1870 Census), 13; Williamson (male; transcribed as “William” but this appears to be incorrect; this is likely the “Anderson” shown as 6 months old in the 1870 Census), 10; James, 9; Clara, 5; Polly, 2; and Mary, 1. All the children are single, black and b. in Alabama. All the children are listed as “at home” except for “student” Celia. None of the family members have their birth month listed, although there is a space for this.

The 1890 US Census is of course burned and unavailable.

The 1900 (June 8) US Census for Mobile, Alabama, Whistler, shows Peter Lee as a black widowed male head of household and farm laborer, 70 years old, b. in January 1830, b. in Africa, immigrated in 1859, 41 years in the US, both parents b. in Africa, cannot read or write but can speak English, owns his own home with no mortgage, not employed 8 of the last 12 months. His granddaughter is Feeney Lee, single black female, 6, b. April 1894 in Alabama, with both parents b. in Alabama; and his grandson is Sidney Lee, 8, b. January 1892 in Alabama, with both parents b. in Alabama. There are no children of Peter listed in the household, only these two grandchildren.

Diouf, *ibid.*, p. 211-2 states that Peter “Gumpa” Lee was hit by a train of the Mobile and Bay Shore Railroad Co. in early September 1902 and died, apparently of injuries from the accident, on 11 September 1902. (See the Annex for more information on this accident and resulting case.) Diouf states that Peter’s family consisted of his wife Josephine and children Charles, William, James, Cecilia, Clara, Polly and Mary, and later grandchildren Sidney and Phene. Diouf states that Peter died intestate, and his estate consisted of personal property of \$10 and two houses and two acres of property worth \$40. Diouf reasons that all of Peter’s family except his grandchildren pre-deceased him. Diouf notes that Peter’s friend Nick Caffey took the train accident matter to court on behalf of Peter’s estate and his grandchildren, and won a small award. (Note that my list of Peter’s children and the spelling of their names differs slightly from Diouf’s; see list below.)

From these records the following facts can reasonably be asserted:

1. Peter Lee was b. in west Africa, likely in what is now Benin, near or in modern day Ouidah (Whyday, Juda, Juida, Glexwe) in about January 1830, and was transported on the *Clotilda* to Mobile, Alabama in 1860 (or possibly on an earlier, unrecorded voyage in 1859).
2. Peter Lee married/liased bef. 1870 (and likely about 1862-3) to Josephine (African name or maiden name unknown) in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler. She was b. in Africa, likely in what is now Benin or Nigeria c. 1840-48, and d. bef. 1900 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler.

3. Peter Lee died 11 September 1902, after being hit by a train in Mobile County earlier in September.
4. The children of Peter and Josephine Lee (all with the last name of Lee) included at least the following:

Lucy, b.c. 1864 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
Charles, b.c. 1867 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
Celia, b.c. 1868 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
Williamson (or "Anderson"?), b.c. 1869, in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
James, b.c. 1871 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
Clara, b.c. 1875 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
Polly, b.c. 1878 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler
Mary, b.c. 1879 in Mobile County, Alabama, likely in Whistler

5. The grandchildren of Peter and Josephine Lee lived with Peter in his house as evidenced by the 1900 Census. These grandchildren were Feeney (likely a nickname for "Josephine," see the 1910 Census material below) Lee and Sidney Robert Lee.

It thus appears that any toys or other children's items found in the house of Peter "Gumpa" Lee via archaeological excavations would likely have belonged to the two grandchildren listed above, or perhaps to his own children listed above.

ANNEX 1: Nick Caffey

The 1902 Mobile County Probate Court case brought by Nick Caffey on behalf of Peter “Gumpa” Lee and his estate is shown in part below; the source is Ancestry.com at:
https://www.ancestry.com/discoveryui-content/view/9476510:8799?tid=&pid=&queryId=0557edbf25cb79afce5cd10b6057d39d&_phsrc=GXY8&_phstart=successSource

The 1910 Federal Census for Mobile, Alabama, Precinct 9 shows Sidney Lee, 17, black male single wagon driver, adopted son of head of household Nick Caffey, 49; living in a household on Magazine Point, with Nick’s spouse Frozene Caffey, 23 and Nick’s adopted daughter Josephine Lee, 16.

Find-a-Grave asserts that “Sidreey” (s/b Sidney, a transcription error) Robert Lee was b. 26 August 1893 in Mobile County, Alabama, and d. 14 May 1962, aged 68, in Mobile County. It seems almost certain that this Sidney Lee is the grandson of Peter and Josephine Lee, listed in the 1900 Census above as b. in January 1892 in Alabama but in the 1910 Census as b.c. 1893. [Note however that about 30 family trees on Ancestry.com cite no biological father for Sidney, or cite his “adoptive father” as Nick Caffey. Similarly, there are seven family trees on Ancestry that assert no biological father for Josephine Lee but several that cite an adoptive father of Nick Caffey for Josephine.] See the obituary below for Sidney Robert Lee, from an unknown source (found on Ancestry) but likely the *Mobile Press Register*. Also see the death notice below, showing his father is unknown but his mother is Mamie Lee, and his gravestone, showing the apparently misspelling “Sidreey” Lee. Note that the Find-a-Grave entry also asserts names and dates for Sidney Lee’s wife Hattie and five children. Assuming “Mamie Lee” is a daughter of Peter “Gumpa” Lee, it is not clear which of Peter’s daughters “Mamie” is.

To Hon. Price Williams, Jr., Judge of Probate for Mobile County:

Your Petitioner, Nick Caffee, would most respectfully represent unto your Honor, that he is a resident citizen of the county of Mobile, State of Alabama, and is over the age of twenty-one years; that Peter Lee departed this life intestate on the 11th day of September, 1902, and left surviving him two minor grandchildren, a girl named Phene Lee, aged about 8 years and a boy named Sydney Lee, age about 9 years, who constituted his family at the time of his death and are his only heirs and distributees to the best of Petitioner's knowledge, information and belief, and he so states; that said Peter Lee was run over and knocked off of the track of the Mobile & Bay Shore Railroad Company, a corporation, wrongfully and negligently, and from the injuries he sustained was killed or died shortly after from said injuries caused by the negligence of said Mobile & Bay Shore Railroad Company; that said Peter Lee left a disputed claim for damages against said Bay Shore Railroad Company and some little personalty, not exceeding Ten Dollars, and two acres of land with a couple of houses or shanties on it, and according to Petitioner's best knowledge, information and belief not worth in value over Forty Dollars, on account of its location and surroundings near Plateau, in said Mobile county; that the two minors herein mentioned are now living with and are being supported and maintained by Petitioner at his own expense; that letters of administration are necessary upon said estate for the purpose of collecting by suit or otherwise the claim for damages for the negligent killing of Petitioner's intestate and to support and maintain said minors out of whatever is realized after paying the expense of realing on said claim against said Railroad Company.

Wherefore your Petitioner prays that letters of administration upon the estate be granted him according to law, upon his giving the requisite bond and security, etc. *Nick Caffee*
Sworn to and subscribed to before me, this the 2nd day of October, 1902.

Price Williams Jr.
Judge

REV. SIDNEY ROBERT LEE—A native and lifelong resident of 438 Bay Bridge Rd., Plateau, Ala., passed away at his late residence Monday, May 14, 1962, at 5:10 p.m. He is survived by one son, Mr. Raymond R. Lee, Chicago, Ill.; four daughters, Mrs. Clara Hodges, Detroit, Mich., Mrs. Jessie Bracy, Mrs. Josephine Marshall, Mrs. Velma Chambers, Mobile, Ala.; twenty-six grandchildren, seven great-grandchildren; two daughters-in-law, Mrs. Willie Nell Lee, Mobile, Ala., Mrs. Agnes Lee, Chicago, Ill.; four sons-in-law, Mr. Jesse Hodges, Detroit, Mich., Mr. John Bracy, Mr. Francis Marshall, Mr. Augustus F. Chambers, Mobile, Ala.; a father-in-law and mother-in-law, Mr. and Mrs. Sam Stallworth; one sister-in-law, Mrs. Sarah Franklin; one brother-in-law, Mr. Ben Franklin; a niece and nephew and a host of other relatives and friends. He was the retired pastor of the Holmes Street Baptist Church, Prichard, Ala., having served as pastor of Shiloh Baptist Church, Crichton, Ala., Liberty Baptist Church, Mobile, Ala., Third Baptist Church, Whistler, Ala. He was emeritus first vice president of Mobile Baptist Sunlight Association, assistant auditor of Alabama Baptist State Convention, past patron of Uneeda Chapter O.E.S. No. 432, and a member of the (Elks) Shell Bayou Lodge No. 361. His remains will lie in state in the Union Baptist Church, Plateau, Ala., Thursday, May 17, 1962, from 6 p.m. until the funeral hour. Funeral services will be held Friday, May 18, 1962, at 1 p.m. from the residence, 436 Bay Bridge Rd., Plateau, Ala., and continue from the Union Baptist Church at 1:30 p.m. The Rev. H. H. Smith, pastor and officiating minister. Interment will follow in the family plot in the Plateau Cemetery. Hodge's Funeral Chapel, directing. Taylor H. Hodge Sr., president.

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SEE OTHER SIDE

FILL IN WITH A TYPEWRITER OR WRITE PLAINLY WITH DARK INK. DO NOT USE GREEN NOR RED INK. LEGAL COPIES CANNOT BE MADE IF ENTRIES ARE DIM

ALL ITEMS MUST BE COMPLETE AND ACCURATE

IF NO DOCTOR WAS IN ATTENDANCE MEDICAL CERTIFICATION SHOULD BE COMPLETED BY THE LOCAL HEALTH OFFICER, OR CORONER IF HE IS A PHYSICIAN OR IF INQUEST WAS HELD

VS-2

1055

CERTIFICATE OF DEATH
STATE OF ALABAMA

11881

1. PLACE OF DEATH
a. COUNTY Mobile 49021

2. USUAL RESIDENCE (Where deceased lived. If institution: Residence before admission)
a. STATE Alabama b. COUNTY Mobile

3. IS PLACE OF DEATH INSIDE CITY LIMITS?
YES ☒ NO ☐

4. CITY, TOWN, OR LOCATION Mobile 49021

5. NAME OF HOSPITAL OR INSTITUTION 438 Bay Bridge Rd. Life

6. LENGTH OF STAY IN 1b

7. STREET ADDRESS 438 Bay Bridge Rd.

8. NAME OF DECEASED
First Middle Last
Sidney Robert Lee 020

9. DATE OF DEATH
Month Day Year
5 14 1962

10. SEX Male 11. COLOR OR RACE Negro 12. MARITAL STATUS NEVER MARRIED ☒ WIDOWED ☐ DIVORCED ☐ 13. DATE OF BIRTH 8/26/1893 14. AGE (In years last birthday) 68 15. IF UNDER 1 YEAR Months Days Hours Min. 16. BIRTHPLACE (State or foreign country) Mobile, Alabama 17. CITIZEN OF WHAT COUNTRY? USA

18. USUAL OCCUPATION (Give kind of work done during most of working life) Minister 19. KIND OF BUSINESS OR INDUSTRY Religious 20. NAME OF SURVIVING SPOUSE Hattie Lee

21. FATHER'S NAME Unknown 22. MOTHER'S MAIDEN NAME Mamie Lee

23. WAS DECEASED EVER IN U. S. ARMED FORCES? (Yes, no, or unknown) (If yes, give war or dates of service) No 24. SOCIAL SECURITY NO. 25. INFORMANT'S NAME Mrs. Velma Chambers 26. ADDRESS 438 Bay Bridge Rd. Mobile

27. CAUSE OF DEATH (Enter only one cause per line for (a), (b), and (c).)
PART I. DEATH WAS CAUSED BY:
IMMEDIATE CAUSE (a) Acute Congestive Heart Failure
Conditions, if any, which gave rise to above cause (a), (b), or (c) Anterograde conduction
lying cause last, DUE TO (c) Vascular disease 4221
PART II. OTHER SIGNIFICANT CONDITIONS CONTRIBUTING TO DEATH BUT NOT RELATED TO THE TERMINAL DISEASE CONDITION GIVEN IN PART I(a)

28. (Probably) ACCIDENT, SUICIDE, HOMICIDE ☐ ☐ ☐ 29. DESCRIBE HOW INJURY OCCURRED. (Enter nature of injury in Part I or Part II of item 18.)

30. TIME OF HOUR, Month, Day, Year
INJURY a. m. p. m.

31. INJURY OCCURRED WHILE AT WORK ☐ NOT WHILE WORK ☐ AT WORK ☐ 32. PLACE OF INJURY (a. g., in or about home, farm, factory, street, office)

33. CITY, TOWN, OR LOCATION COUNTY STATE

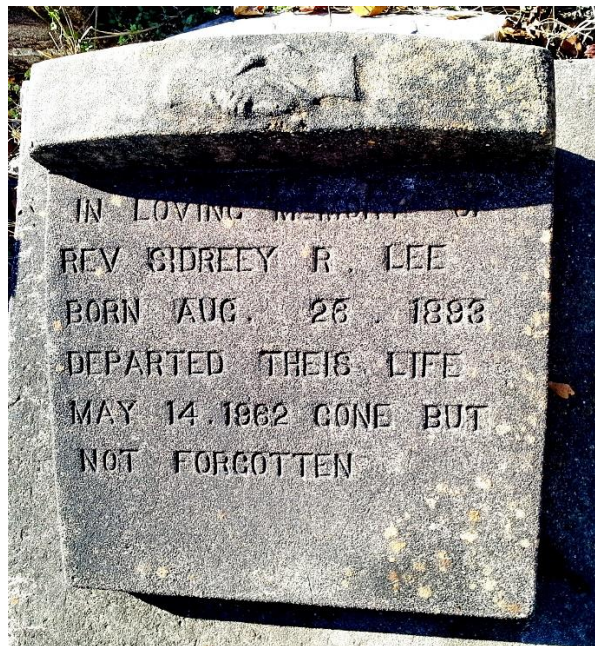
34. I attended the deceased from 5-15-62 to 5-12-62 and last saw her alive on 5-12-62
Death occurred at 5:10 p. m. on the date stated above; and to the best of my knowledge, from the causes stated.

35. SIGNATURE (Physician) M. V. Fortenberry M.D. 36. DATE SIGNED 5-15-62 37. SIGNATURE (Health Officer) M. D. Davis M.D. 38. DATE SIGNED 5-15-62

39. BURIAL, CREMATION, REMOVAL (Specify) 40. DATE 5/18/1962 41. NAME OF CEMETERY OR CREMATORY Plateau Cemetery 42. LOCATION (City, town, or county) Plateau, Alabama (State)

43. FUNERAL DIRECTOR ADDRESS 44. DATE RECD. BY LOCAL REG. MAY 17 1962 45. REGISTRAR'S SIGNATURE Blake Dine

Hodges Funeral Chapel, Mobile



From the information above in this Annex, it appears likely (but not certain) that various living persons who think that they are descended from Nick Caffey (or have hit a “brick wall” at their “adoptive” ancestor Nick Caffey) are in fact biologically descended from Peter “Gumpa” Lee and Josephine Lee, and that these living persons could probably prove that descent, with enough genealogical research.

ANNEX 2: Information on the Author

Lew Toulmin is a genealogist, explorer, travel writer and policy analyst with expertise in telecommunications policy, e-government, emergency management, public administration reform, and economic analysis. He is a Fellow of the Royal Geographical Society and of the Royal Society of Arts. His website is www.themosttraveled.com, Facebook page is <https://www.facebook.com/llewellyn.toulmin/>, and monthly travel/adventure/exploration column in the online Montgomery County, Maryland newspaper “MyMCM” is at: <https://www.mymcmedia.org/category/community-blogs/travel-tales/>. His travel/adventure book *The Most Traveled Man on Earth* is available on Amazon and e-bay, and his 40+ academic and professional reports on *Clotilda*/Africatown descendants, other genealogical and historical research, exploration, and on topics in public administration are available at: <https://independent.academia.edu/LlewellynToulmin>.

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